Past Participle Accord in Passé Composé

The agreement of the past participle depends on the auxiliary verb, the position of the direct object pronoun, and other factors. Most verbs in French are conjugated with **'avoir'** as the helping/auxiliary verb, and in those cases, the past participle never agrees with the gender and number of the subject.

Past Participle Accord with Avoir as Auxiliary

The past participle **does not agree in gender and number** with the direct object if the **Direct Object/Direct Object Pronoun is placed after the auxiliary verb.** For instance:

J'ai trouvé une lettre. (I found a letter.)

Here, the direct object 'une lettre' is placed after the auxiliary verb *avoir*. As a result, agreement of the past participle is not required.

However, if the **Direct Object / Direct Object Pronoun precedes the auxiliary verb avoir**, in that case, the past participle **agrees in gender and number with the direct object / direct object pronoun.**

Hier, j'ai trouvé une lettre. Ma sœur **l'**a écrit**e.** (Yesterday, I found a letter. My sister wrote it.)

In the above sentence, the direct object pronoun 'la' (replacing the Direct Object 'la lettre') precedes the auxiliary verb avoir. Thus, the accord past participle agrees with la.

Français	English
Tu as posé des questions stupides pendant le débat. Le jury ne **les** a pas aimé**es**.	You asked some stupid questions in the debate. The jury didn't like them.
Donald a acheté des livres la semaine dernière. Enfin, il les a **lus** hier soir.	Donald bought some books last week. Finally, he read them last night.
Le matin, ils ont écouté ces chansons populaires. En fait, ils les ont connu**es** par cœur.	In the morning, they listened to these pop songs. In fact, they knew them by heart.

Avant-hier, Ashok a acheté des livres. Hier, je les ai lus.	The day before yesterday, Ashok bought some books. I read them yesterday.

Past Participle Accord with Être as Auxiliary

Generally, the past participle **agrees in gender and number** with the subject when the verb être is used as an auxiliary verb.

Français	English
Ils sont parti**s** pour Agra en voiture.	They left for Agra by car.
Nous sommes allé**s** au bord de la mer pendant les vacances.	We went to the seaside during the vacation.
Ivanka est passé**e** devant la maison de Kaustubh.	Ivanka passed by Kaustubh's home.
Ils sont né**s** en 2001.	They were born in 2001.

Accord Rules for Reflexive Verbs with Direct Object

If the reflexive verb has a direct object that follows the helping verb Être, then t**he past participle doesn't agree with the subject** in number and gender**.**

Elle s'est lavé le visage.

There is no accord with the subject, as the reflexive verb is followed by a direct object (le visage). However, in the reformulation of this sentence if we replace the direct object **le visage** with a pronoun **le**, and it comes before the auxiliary verb être, **the past participle will then agree with** the number and gender of **the direct object pronoun**.

Elle s'est lavé les mains. (She washed her hands.)
Oui, elle se **les** est lavé**es**.

The past participle agrees with the direct object pronouns, which are feminine plural here—referring to ***les mains***.

Français	English
Elle s'est coupé**e**. Elle s'est coupé le doigt.	She cut herself. She cut her finger.

Ivanka s’est lavé**e**.	Ivanka washed herself.
Ils se sont blessé**s**.	They injured themselves.
Elle s'est brossé les dents. Oui, elle **les** a bien brossé**es**.	She brushed her teeth. Yes, she brushed them well.